THE BOOK AND ITS REVIEWERS

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Appointment in Crete was published by Allan Wingate of 12 Beauchamp Place, London, on 16 July 1953, at fifteen shillings, in a dust jacket designed by the author's friend the painter John Craxton. It was reviewed in The Times on 22 July and in the Times Literary Supplement two days later, and noticed in a dozen other papers and journals that summer and autumn. The pages that follow gather those reviews that could be recovered, the publisher's own description of the book, and a note of the historians who have drawn on it since. They are not part of the original book.

THE SPHERE
15 August 1953

The World of Books

Appointment in Crete (Wingate. 15s.) is the story of a British agent, with a difference, and that lies in the fact that its author, Mr. A. M. Rendel, found himself leading this life of highly-coloured adventure almost by chance. Classical scholar turned solicitor turned soldier, in 1943 he was in Cairo, dining with another English officer, an old friend, who suggested that he might be suitable for a more irregular kind of job—organising the fifth column against the Germans in Crete. Mr. Rendel accepted and, so far as one can gather from his lively narrative, took to it like a

duck to water, relishing everything from his hastily-grown brigand's moustache to gun-running, sabotage, the landing of agents by sea and air and general extra-curricular activities. His modern Greek was little and his training for a life on the run even less, but, with many of his companions, he survived to tell the story of another British victory and of Greek friendship.
Vernon Fane

THE SPECTATOR
25 September 1953

Cretan Labyrinth

"No. There isn't much chance of washing and you don't feel much inclined in this cold weather. *They* never do." "They," of course, are the Cretans. And if you disregard an unfortunate book-cover, *Appointment in Crete* plunges at once into an atmosphere conspiratorial yet typically British. For this is a very British book; highly individual, moving and permeated with that "amateur" spirit whose enthusiasm and initiative have seldom failed to make the stories of our "side-shows" the most popular accounts of the last two wars. If one should occasionally wonder whether so much hardship and risk achieved much beyond showing the British flag, that is certainly not the fault of the author, whose endearing personality emerges early in the book and sustains us for some fifty pages until he is hidden away in the mountains overlooking the plain of Heraklion.

Besides a fine blend of modesty and courage, Major Rendel's qualifications for a very hazardous year in Crete were an ability to read ancient Greek and a somewhat hazy memory of a five-week walking tour twelve years earlier on the Greek mainland. Is it any wonder that, at

first, his mission was not blessed with success? Whilst landing, he loses overboard, not only the cunningly camouflaged charging engine for his wireless but his precious suitcase containing propaganda leaflets, maps, identity cards and an invaluable Greek dictionary. But a voice is hailing from the shore. Rendel lands, an outgoing Italian General takes his place in the boat and the new British agent is in the midst of a boisterous Cretan welcome—soon to dissolve into angry bickering.

And thus—in the autumn of 1943—Rendel's Cretan Appointment begins; a period of heart-breaking initiation when, out of touch with Cairo, a long series of misfortunes and disappointments only serve to bring out his better qualities. And soon the tide is turning. He builds up a private band of Cretans clad in black sarikis, shepherd's breeches and jackboots soled with strips from motor tyres, who are to be his faithful companions. Soon he is organising an intelligence network, making long and difficult marches through the country and vainly endeavouring to rally the diverse elements of Cretan resistance. This is a well-told story of a hard, adventurous year, which never fails to hold the attention; air-drops, demolitions, coping with Rosebud and Clubfoot the Communist leaders, hide-and-seek with the German patrols and a penetration into German-occupied Heraklion where he sets up his wireless next door to German wireless headquarters. It is exciting and genuine. But it is more than that. Rendel has caught the atmosphere of the island; the mountains, the little villages, the plain shimmering with heat. He has caught, too, in a dozen little portraits, its remarkable people; the members of his band, the guides and shepherds, the hospitable, but dangerously loquacious villagers, the Archimandrite of the monastery where Rendel hides beneath the floor boards from a German patrol. Nor at the

moment of triumph, amidst the flowers and shouting and the bottle of champagne does he forget the burnt-out villages and the white crosses which are the burden of those who organise a resistance movement. Whether taking tea in a house beneath the noses of the Germans or encountering villagers picking snails after rain, Rendel is always conscious of his friends—the Cretans; brave beyond discretion, brimming with tragi-comic heroism, vital with a resilience which has survived both Turk and German. *Appointment in Crete* is a book that will not be easily forgotten. It is too genuine, too sincere; constantly illuminated with little flashes that tell their own revealing story. "Well, Mr. Alexis," says Friar Tuck, the Orthodox priest with parachute wings, placing a chair amidst the ruins of his house, "I always said that one day I would welcome you to my home. As you see there's not much left of it but at least we can offer you a glass."
James Kinross

THE NEW STATESMAN AND NATION
26 September 1953

Scenes of Military Life

War digs its roots deep and spreads its branches wide. For fifteen years past all of us, whether dons, mechanics, bricklayers or accountants, have been sucked out of our native soil and scattered in every unlikely corner of the world to do unfamiliar jobs under conditions of primitive discomfort and danger. Civilisation softens and urbanises us, replacing our horses by underground trains, our skills in hunting and digging by a taste for the ballet or for football pools; yet at any moment, having deprived us of our physical capital, she may, Mephistophelean, present her bill and send us to live and die in a savage wilderness

at the world's end.

This is the situation which both Mr. Rendel and Major Campbell describe in their books: the scattering of Englishmen to the mountains of Crete or the jungles of Malaya and their painful and successful adaptation to hardships for which nothing in their lives has prepared them. The types of Englishmen with which they deal are widely different. *Appointment in Crete,* an account of Mr. Rendel's life as a British agent during the war, is a good work in the tradition made familiar by Julian Amery and Fitzroy Maclean in the recent war, by T. E. Lawrence in the last. Byron is the patron saint of these versatile, independent and courageous spirits for whom regimental life, with its football matches and adjutants' parades and the back numbers of *Sport and Country* in the Mess, is merely an extension of the ennui of peace. In private life scholars, travellers or journalists, no rut detains them long. Happily they escape from units embarrassed by their presence, to wrap themselves in a *burnous* or a peasant's hood and lead in deserts or mountain caves a hard and healthy life seasoned with the thrills of hunting and the terrors of being hunted. The contrasts of their existence, the rapid alternation of silk sheets with rock floors, of repletion with starvation, is the breath of their being. Aristocrats, they accept luxury or squalor; only the humdrum is more than they can bear.

Mr. Rendel describes his life as an outlaw simply and objectively, without dramatic distortion. He makes very clear a point which books of this type tend to obscure—that the work of the British was merely ancillary to a sturdy native movement of independence in which we were accepted as *bona fide* allies; and he writes with charity both of the Germans and—what is even rarer—of his superiors in Cairo. The British Army uses its irregulars as intelligently as the Roman Church, which allows its

fanatics to found new preaching orders. We are shown how this cloak-and-dagger department fitted in to the general activity of the Middle East; how it was provided with supplies—dehydrated carrots, Army pants, mines disguised as camel-dung—and how it passed its information. We are lucky that Mr. Rendel survived to write this agreeable and impressive book; a tendency to confuse cyanide pills with raisins made it a near thing.

Jungle Green is yet more impressive and considerably less agreeable: to read it is not a pleasure but a bitter duty. It deals not with the adventurous exceptions but with the ordinary run-of-the-mill conscripts, young men from cosy suburbs who have been chosen by the fortunes of war to carry out in Malaya "duties in aid of the civil power": the hunting and capture of Communist guerrillas. Major Campbell is a regular soldier who shares with such predecessors as Rifleman Harris the ability to describe hardship and horror without a trace of self-pity. The sufferings which he and his men endured, and presumably are still enduring, were continuous, intense and, for the most part, unrewarding. Every form of discomfort combines in the jungle: stinging insects, fœtid heat and clammy cold, deep swamps and violent rivers, fever, hunger, physical danger from the enemy and, perhaps worst of all, the claustrophobic oppression of imprisonment in thick undergrowth through which even by day little light could pierce—and much of the patrolling took place at night. Somehow men from England have to be knocked into the physical and mental shape to endure such a life, to treat the jungle as their native habitat and meet the guerrillas on their own terms, and Major Campbell shows clearly and grimly how this is being done.

The chief flaw in the book is one which will guarantee its success as a best-seller. To reduce experience to

coherent form without distortion is the basic problem facing any memoir writer, and here the form is suspiciously coherent. One suspects, lurking in the background, the figure of someone who knows the literary ropes and has licked the work into shape. Long conversations are reported in *oratio recta;* the plot centres round the pursuit of a bandit chief who is caught on the last page, having killed the best man under the author's command; and whatever the book gains in readability by this, it loses in conviction. Nor does Major Campbell emerge quite unscathed from the ordeals he so brilliantly describes. Massacre and violence are described with a little too much gusto. He asked a police officer how much the trial of a bandit cost and received the answer that "a very rough estimate would run at well over £2,000. I added in the cost in time and trouble of the witnesses. The total gave me food for thought. A bullet costs 1½d."

That reflection gives us food for thought also. When men have to cleanse themselves of the softness of civilisation, can they preserve its ethical values intact?

Michael Howard

A joint review, under the heading "Scenes of Military Life", of Appointment in Crete (Allan Wingate, 15s.) and Arthur Campbell's Jungle Green (Allen & Unwin, 12s. 6d.). It is given whole, since its argument runs through both books. It is signed Michael Howard: the military historian (1922–2019), then a young lecturer at King's College London and later Regius Professor of Modern History at Oxford.

BRITISH BOOK NEWS
October 1953

The more spectacular exploits of British officers in Crete during the occupation have already been very well publicised. This is the first account of the equally

dangerous but more solid work of the underground, the routine collection of intelligence, the planning and execution of sabotage, and the unrelenting toil and self-sacrifice of officers, agents and civilians which kept resistance groups in the field for years on end. The author spent eighteen months in Eastern Crete. His exciting story pays a long-deserved tribute to the pioneers such as Dunbabin and Leigh-Fermor, and shows a sensible understanding as well as deep admiration for the Cretans.
The British Council's monthly guide to new books. Unsigned.

THE ANNUAL REGISTER
1953

. . . for connoisseurs of Resistance literature was A. M. Rendel's Appointment in Crete (Wingate). Although a personal account, it had the merit of putting earlier best-sellers into perspective . . .
From the survey of the year's literature; only the opening of the notice could be recovered.

FOREIGN AFFAIRS (NEW YORK)
July 1954

Another cloak and dagger memoir—this time by a British agent in occupied Crete during the war.
From the "Recent Books" column of the Council on Foreign Relations' quarterly.

THE PUBLISHER'S DESCRIPTION, FROM THE JACKET

This is a personal account of the adventures, thoughts and feelings of an ordinary citizen who found himself suddenly, and more or less by chance, a British agent in

Crete. There, in the mountains for over a year, he lived, in his own words, a life "real to the point of intensity and romantic to the point of melodrama."

From the rather humdrum existence of a classical scholar turned solicitor, Rendel found himself, as a result of a chance encounter in a Cairo restaurant, transformed almost overnight into a moustachioed conspirator, dressed as a Greek peasant, living in shepherds' caves or hidden in monastery cellars, and finally running a secret wireless inside Herakleion. He became a desperado seasoned in gun-running and the landing of agents by air and sea, in the direction of an intelligence net, in clandestine meetings between rival outlaws in the hills, and in fifth-column work such as the burning of petrol dumps and other sorts of sabotage against the occupation forces. He was often on the run from German patrols in the mountains and on the open plain, and he describes with fidelity and humour his vagabond life among the villagers with whom, at first, he could only share a few broken words of modern Greek, yet who fed him, hid him, guided him and, in many cases, became his lifelong friends.

Appointment in Crete is a completely authentic, full-blooded and, at the same time, sensitive and almost poetic account of high adventure, very much in the tradition of *Dare To Be Free.* Once again we find a young Britisher who, through his . . . [the remainder of the blurb, on the back flap, is still to be recovered from an original jacket].

ABOUT THE AUTHOR, FROM THE JACKET

A. M. Rendel was born in London in 1910 and was educated at Rugby and Corpus Christi College, Oxford. After leaving the University, he worked as a freelance journalist in the Saar and Geneva, travelled widely in

Europe, including Greece, and then worked for four years in a solicitor's office in the City.

He had just married when the outbreak of war took him to an artillery O.C.T.U. in November, 1939. His first three years of soldiering were spent uneventfully in the United Kingdom, Persia and Iraq, and it was a chance encounter that brought him suddenly into the midst of the resistance movement in Crete, where his adventures form the subject of this book.

He returned to Greece with his family after the war, and worked for three years in the British Embassy in Athens. He now lives in London with his wife and five children.

Reviews also appeared in The Times (22 July 1953, page 11) and in the Times Literary Supplement (page 471, 24 July 1953). Their texts are held in the newspapers' digital archives, which most public libraries can reach, and would be a welcome addition to this appendix.

THE BOOK IN LATER HISTORIES

Patrick Leigh Fermor, in his introduction and notes to George Psychoundakis's The Cretan Runner (1955), calls Appointment in Crete "an excellent account" and identifies its author as "Sandy Rendel—Alexis—who works on The Times". In Abducting a General (2014) he recalls "I stayed with Sandy Rendel in his cave for over a month . . . in the Lasithi mountains" before the kidnapping of General Kreipe.

W. Stanley Moss, Ill Met by Moonlight (1950), describes Rendel as "the Times correspondent, the polished and educated" officer who met the kidnap party; the 1957 film gave the part of Captain Sandy Rendel to Cyril Cusack.

Dilys Powell, The Villa Ariadne (1973), and Adam

Hopkins, Crete: Its Past, Present and People (1977), draw on the book; Hopkins calls it "a good companion" to Xan Fielding's Hide and Seek and retells Rendel's peace-making feast between rival bands.

Antony Beevor, Crete: The Battle and the Resistance (1991), quotes Rendel on the Cairo farewell that "seemed all too like a third-rate thriller and therefore faintly bogus", on the cyanide pills he carried in his jacket pocket, and on his arrival in Lasithi.

Artemis Cooper, Patrick Leigh Fermor: An Adventure (2012); Wes Davis, The Ariadne Objective (2013), which quotes the book by permission of Robert Rendel; and Rick Stroud, Kidnap in Crete (2015), which opens a chapter with Rendel in his cave on 5 February 1944 and cites a letter of his among the papers of Annette Crean at the Imperial War Museum.

An extract, "A First Parachute Jump", was anthologised in school readers from the 1960s to the 1990s (A Mirror of the Times, 1964; Speech for Life, 1966; Thoughtweavers, 1979; Tradewinds, 1990).

THE TIMES
Thursday 21 November 1991

SANDY RENDEL

Alexander "Sandy" Meadows Rendel, CBE, diplomatic correspondent of The Times, 1952–75, died on November 14 aged 81. He was born on May 14, 1910.

A CHANCE meeting with an old friend in wartime Cairo led to Sandy Rendel, an artillery officer in Iran, being seconded to special forces based in Crete. He was to live the next two years in mountain caves, dressed as a shepherd, as a liaison officer with the Greek resistance.

His recruitment had been quaintly British. His qualifications were a classical education, acquired at Rugby and Corpus Christi, Oxford, and a pre-war walking tour on the Greek mainland. Yet after a short course of instruction he slipped ashore one moonless night in 1943 on one of the more hazardous operations of the war. Rendel, special agent, communicated with his new allies in ancient Greek, which he wrote on scraps of paper in bold capitals. They replied in similar manner in modern Greek, thus establishing a rapport between scholar and peasants which underpinned their espionage activities. The danger was compounded by the locals who, whenever a new hide-out was established, could not resist coming from miles around to stare at it. But the Germans were fortunately wary of the hills and kept their search and destroy raids to a minimum.

Sandy Rendel's adventures were used by W. Stanley

Moss in his yarn about wartime Crete *Ill Met by Moonlight,* later to be filmed successfully. His own less flamboyant account, *Appointment in Crete,* was favourably reviewed in 1953. By then he had embarked on a new job as diplomatic correspondent of *The Times* in which he remained for the rest of his career. So clearly was "A. M. Rendel" identified with the post that it is hard now to think of him occupying any other. Yet he was touching forty when he joined the newspaper and he did so after trying his hand at other occupations.

His first ambition was to be a diplomat. But although he passed the Foreign Office entrance he did not do well enough to win a place. He switched to the law but, with some time to spare, went first on a travelling holiday to the continent. This gave him his first taste for journalism. Introduced to *The Times* correspondent in the Saar, he was asked to help out while the other man went on holiday. The year was 1935, when the Saarlanders voted by plebiscite to be reincorporated into Germany. Rendel's first file, an exclusive story, was promptly spiked in Printing House Square, whose editors seemed not to have been told of the staff change. The next day the *Express* used the story, whereupon *The Times* had the grace to apologise — and ask Rendel to send it again. He later wrote the "splash" and remained in the Saar for three months.

The next four years were spent in a solicitor's office, before and after qualifying. He then moved to a Quaker educational settlement in the Rhondda for six months, which took him up to the outbreak of the war. After VE-Day he stayed in Greece, first as regional officer for the UN Association, then on attachment to the British Embassy in Athens.

He was given a more formal introduction to *The Times* on returning home, however, and joined the staff on

August 1, 1949, first as assistant diplomatic correspondent, then taking over the job itself in 1952. An early coup was an interview with Tito on Yugoslavia's internal problems – a report which seems wryly pertinent today. Another "scoop", which gave him less pleasure some years later, was his story which led the paper on May 3, 1966, the day on which news permanently replaced advertisements on page one. "London to be new HQ for Nato" it announced, following the alliance's eviction from France. Alas, Rendel's speculative masterpiece, which was subsequently flashed round the world, had one thing wrong. To his chagrin, Nato ended up in Brussels.

Sandy Rendel was a journalist of the old school in all senses of the phrase. He was full of old-fashioned integrity and charm, a modest, courteous envoy of his newspaper and his craft. His were the days in which the man from *The Times* was briefed individually by the Foreign Office, though Sandy maintained this had its disadvantages. He travelled widely, though decreasingly – and regretted the decline of London as a world centre of decision-making.

He worked briefly for the Council of Europe after retiring, then devoted his time to his grandchildren and fly-fishing – at which he was skilled and successful. He is survived by his wife Elizabeth and five children.

Reproduced for the family from The Times of 21 November 1991, page 20; the text is the copyright of Times Newspapers Ltd. The printed column has a photograph of him in later life. One misprint ("succesful") has been corrected.